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ON THE SIDELINES

By Jim Ogle

Andy Cohen, a character

ST. PETERSBURG, Fla., Feb. 28 — Baseball is loaded with legendary characters. Andy Cohen qualifies by dint of hard work and persistence, which has enabled him to remain in baseball 30 years in a variety of jobs and places but always surrounded by friends.

Signed to a Waco contract while still in high school, Cohen got an athletic scholarship to the University of Alabama where he was a three-letter man and played in the backfield with Johnny Mack Brown, All-American fullback and later a movie star.

Cohen, who has acquired thousands of friends and an unbeatable knowledge of U.S. geography during his career, was 19 when he broke in with Waco in 1925 and clicked so solidly that he was sold to the Giants for \$25,000, but with the provision he remain a second year in Waco. Three weeks after the 1926 season opener, Travis Jackson was hurt and Cohen was a Giant.

"All I had to do was beat out Frankie Frisch," Andy recalls. "I didn't, but stayed around all year and went south with the Giants in 1927 with Rogers Hornsby to beat out."

Andy was optioned to Buffalo in 1927 and hit .335 to help the Bisons win the pennant, then was handed the toughest assignment any rookie has ever been given.

"I was the replacement for Hornsby, who had been sold to Boston," Cohen says, smiling. "I got off to a flying start as we won the opener, 5-3, and I knocked in three runs and scored two. I hit .274 as we lost the pennant by one game."

"I hit .294 in 1929," Andy recalls, "but I hurt a thigh and didn't tell anyone. McGraw decided I had football legs and was too slow so he sold me to Newark for Hub Pruett. I played two years in Newark and had a good year under Al Mamaux in 1931. I hit .318 and set a fielding record with 59 straight games and 312 chances without an error."

"I opened the 1932 season with Newark, which was now in the Yankee chain," Cohen says. "I won the opening game with a ninth inning grand slam, but the Yanks had paid \$75,000 for Jack Saltzgaver and, when he was sent to Newark, George Weiss sold me to Minneapolis."

On tour with Cohen

"I stayed in Minneapolis until the middle of the 1939 season," Cohen says. "Larry MacPhail had come to Brooklyn and offered me a job as playing manager with Pine Bluff in the Cotton States League. Later I moved to Dayton, but after one more year had a disagreement with Larry and moved to Elmira in 1941. I was 35 by now, but I was single and loved to play ball although I could have made more doing something else. I don't think I could stand it if I didn't have something to do connected with baseball."

"Elmira was a great break for me," Andy says with a laugh. "I met the girl I married there and we have three children and still live in Elmira. In the winter I work in a clothing store and also do some subbing in the school system."

It took a war to get Andy out of baseball, for a while, and for the next three years he was a first sergeant in the Engineers and participated in the North African invasion and the Italian campaigns.

After the war Andy took on a real job—part-owner and player-manager of the El Paso club in the Mexican National League. That lasted through the 1946 season.

In 1947 he was a scout for the Boston Braves but returned to managing in 1948 at Eau Claire. He remained there three years, then moved over to Denver, then in the Western League, and after one year it became part of the Pittsburgh farm system.

"The Pirates moved me to New Orleans in 1955 and I stayed there for two years. Then I moved to Indianapolis last season under the White Sox and now, at last, I am in the Yankee organization and very glad to be here. Incidentally, I forgot to tell you I was also general manager those years in Eau Claire."

Many jobs and many friends

Wherever Andy has played he has become a popular figure. It was once said of him that the fans in various cities had given him so many days that he could open his own pawnshop and have a complete stock.

In 1927 he must have set a record for days—he was not only honored in Buffalo, where he was a hero, but in rival cities of Baltimore and Syracuse. He was given a day at the Polo Grounds in 1928 and since has been given days in New Orleans and Denver. Among the loot he collected was a \$2,500 check, two automobiles and a diamond ring.

"In 1931 I was voted the "most popular Bear" by the fans," Andy recalls. "They gave me a big cup which I

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